

How to Stop AI From Building Websites That Look Like AI

A checklist from @jez.escapes who built the ugly version first then spent weeks to fix it.

I built the first version of my product's homepage almost entirely with AI. It looked OK to me at the time but then I started noticing the same problems again and again, on my own site and on other people's. Once you know what to look for, you can tell the AI exactly what to avoid.

Here is my checklist. Give these instructions to whatever tool you are using, or read your own page against them. I use these on every project now.

1. Vary your spacing and make some things clearly more important

The most common problem is that every section gets the same amount of padding and the same visual weight. The whole page ends up with one even rhythm, so nothing feels important because everything looks the same.

I want some contrast now. A large open hero at the top, then a tighter section packed with detail, then some open space again. Tell your AI to change the spacing between sections and to give the hero much more room than everything else. Ask it to make sure the eye knows where to look first, second, and third. If you scroll your page and it feels like one long, even column, that is what you need to change.

2. Understand what AI can and cannot do with movement

This one surprised me, so let me explain how it works. When AI adds an animation, it almost always writes CSS keyframes or transitions on an SVG that it drew, or it fades and slides a box around. So the movement is real, but it is usually a shape wiggling or floating on a loop, with no reason behind it.

What AI will not do on its own is the harder work: real video, movement that responds as you scroll, parallax depth, a hero that changes as you move down the page, or elements that appear in a planned sequence with proper timing. Those need a motion library set up correctly and a person deciding what should move and why.

My old homepage had AI-animated SVGs bouncing around for no reason. The new one has a scroll-based hero, parallax, and real video. If you want movement that adds something, you have to plan it yourself. The AI will add decoration, but it will not plan the motion for you.

3. Choose your fonts and stick to them

Left to its own choices, AI tends to grab a dramatic serif for the headings, a plain sans-serif for the body text, and a monospace font for small labels, then use all three on the same screen. It reads like three different personalities on one page.

Pick one font family and let size and weight separate your headings from your body text. If you genuinely want two fonts, choose two on purpose and write down exactly where each one is used. Then tell the AI never to add a third. Consistent fonts are one of the fastest ways to make a page look considered.

4. Cut headlines that sound clever but do not say anything

AI likes a short, dramatic headline with a full stop after it. "Your money, decoded to the cent." "Take control today." On their own they sound slick. But when you stack a whole page of them, they say nothing, and none of them tell the reader what the product actually does.

I now make every headline say something real. A specific claim, a number, or a clear outcome. If a headline could sit on any product in my category, it is too vague. Ask your AI for headlines that describe what actually happens, and turn down anything you could not explain if someone asked you what it meant.

5. Do not let AI draw a fake version of your product

This is the biggest giveaway of all. AI cannot take a screenshot of your app, so when it needs to show your product, it draws one instead. Invented charts, invented dashboards, boxes arranged to look like a real interface. From a distance it looks convincing. Up close you can see it is made up.

Use real screenshots from the actual product. Real charts built from real data. Screen recordings if you can make them. As soon as you replace a drawn mockup with a real capture of the product working, the whole page becomes more believable.

6. Remove the decorative clutter

When AI does not know how to fill a space, it adds decoration. Dashed lines, small uppercase labels on everything, corner marks, perforated edges, little pulsing dots. Each one looks harmless. Together they make a page feel busy and unsure of itself.

Removing decoration is a choice the AI almost never makes for you, so you have to make it. Go through the page and take out anything that is not carrying real meaning. Empty space is not a problem you need to fill. Most of the time the page looks better with less on it.

7. Connect your sections so the scroll feels continuous

An AI-built page often jumps hard from one background to the next. Cream, then black, then cream again, with nothing to connect them. It feels like separate pages stapled together instead of one continuous scroll.

Think about how each section leads into the next. A gradual change in tone, a shared element that carries across the join, or movement that links one block to the one below it. You want the person scrolling to feel like they are moving through one designed experience, not clicking between unrelated slides.

8. AI gets you to a launched site, but the final polish is your job

This is the mindset that changed everything for me. AI got my site live quickly, and that is genuinely useful. It handled the first large chunk of the work. But the last part, the part that makes something feel considered and human, took me weeks of manual work that the AI was never going to do by itself.

So use AI for what it is good at: getting from nothing to a working first version fast. Then treat everything after that as your responsibility. Taste, restraint, timing, and the hundred small choices that add up to something that does not look generated. That difference is real, and closing it is where the actual work is.

The short version

Vary your spacing. Plan your movement instead of decorating with it. Choose your fonts and stick to them. Write headlines that say something real. Use real screenshots, not drawings. Remove the clutter. Connect your sections. And accept that the final polish is up to you. Check any page you build against this list and you will catch most of the problems before anyone else does.